

LEARNING TO LIVE THE BLESSED LIFE

TEXT: Luke 6:38 (KJV) “Give, and it shall be given unto you; good measure, pressed down, and shaken together, and running over, shall men give into your bosom. For with the same measure that ye mete withal it shall be measured to you again.” Luke 6:38 (NLT) “If you give, you will receive. Your gift will return to you in full measure, pressed down, shaken together to make room for more, and running over. Whatever measure you use in giving—large or small—it will be used to measure what is given back to you.”

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THE LAW OF THE HARVEST

INTRO: God has set into order some laws, one of which is the Law of Harvest. According to the Word of God, this law is irrefutable. Galatians 6:7-10 (NLT) “Don’t be misled. Remember that you can’t ignore God and get away with it. You will always reap what you sow! 8 Those who live only to satisfy their own sinful desires will harvest the consequences of decay and death. But those who live to please the Spirit will harvest everlasting life from the Spirit. 9 So don’t get tired of doing what is good. Don’t get discouraged and give up, for we will reap a harvest of blessing at the appropriate time. 10 Whenever we have the opportunity, we should do good to everyone, especially to our Christian brothers and sisters.”

Any good farmer understands and respects this simple principle. A farmer who makes his living from the soil:

- Prepares the soil...
- Plows...
- Plants...
- Fertilizes...
- Carefully oversees...

- Seeks to protect...

I. THE HEART OF THE SOWER...

I Pastored for a number of years in a farming community, and the lessons I learned from those farmers has greatly enhanced my ability and willingness to give to the Lord. I have yet to meet a farmer who sows his fields without expecting the ground to produce a return. I disagree with people who say we should not sow with an expectation to receive. That is absolutely foolishness. **Every farmer expects an increase in due season.** The farmer who sows without expecting to receive will be out of business in short order.

Thought the farmer plants with an expectation of reaping, **a true farmer makes his living from the ground because he has a love for farming:**

- **He maintains his equipment...** During the winter the true farmer does not spend his days recklessly, he is in the shop getting the equipment ready for the next farming cycle.
- **He plows the ground...** He is preparing it to receive his seed.
- **He Plants the crop...** He understands that unless he makes an investment in sowing there will be no harvest.
- **He tends the crop...** He fertilizes, plows, sprays pesticides, etc...
- **He reaps his reward...** At the right time he goes into the field and gathers the harvest into the silo.

This is the pattern that is repeated year after year, however if the farmer gets hailed out; flooded out; stormed out; droughted out, he is still there the next season because his heart is to farm, he has a connection to the land. The smell of the soil gets him going in the morning! The sound of the equipment working causes the blood to flow properly through his veins! The sound of the combine thrashing the harvest causes his heart to beat a little faster

II. THE MOTIVE OF THE SOWER...

Even though we reap what we sow and expectantly await our harvest, **our motivation for sowing should not necessarily be reaping but giving and sharing.** If our motivation for sowing is reaping alone, if we do not reap what we expected our giving comes to a screeching halt! If the farmer is in the farming business strictly for the harvest, he would quit the first year he made a bad crop!

Many Christians never discover the secret of joyous giving or the blessing of sharing. The Word plainly says **the Father has uniquely designed us to experience the joy of giving and the blessing of sharing.** Acts 20:35 (NLT) ***“And I have been a constant example of how you can help the poor by working hard. You should remember the words of the Lord Jesus: ‘It is more blessed to give than to receive.’”***

When a person begins to experience the exuberance of this kind of giving it is much easier for them to enter this sphere in the future. **The condition of the heart determines whether a person is capable of this kind of giving.** Matthew 6:20-21 (NLT) ***“Store your treasures in heaven, where they will never become moth-eaten or rusty and where they will be safe from thieves. 21 Wherever your treasure is, there your heart and thoughts will also be.”***

A foundational truth for all Christ centered givers is this: **Everything we have belongs to God; we are the steward (Business Managers) of His possessions.** If we truly view ourselves merely as stewards, it makes it much easier to distribute His wealth in a responsible manner. However **if we view the possessions we have been blessed with as our own we tend to:**

- Guard it...
- Hoard it...
- Protect it...
- Keep it...

In such a scenario, we tend to think only of what is good for us, never allowing the heart of God to enter the picture.

III. THE REWARD OF THE SOWER...

When the farmer takes the bob trucks and combines into the field, he knows that months of work are going to be rewarded with a harvest. **The resources the farmer receives from months of labor will be:**

- **Tallied...** He will total up his increase.
- **Taken to the market...** He will sell his harvest for as much as possible.
- **Distributed...** He will lay aside enough money to sow next year's crop and then everyone he owes will get their share.
- **Budgeted...** He will determine his bills and living expenses until the next harvest.

The heart of God is to make stewards of us so He can direct His resources, and when this occurs we experience the completion of the cycle of giving, which is receiving, so we can give again. **Luke 6:38 (NLT) "If you give, you will receive. Your gift will return to you in full measure, pressed down, shaken together to make room for more, and running over. Whatever measure you use in giving—large or small—it will be used to measure what is given back to you."**

Once a person develops this kind of a heart, they are no longer a reservoir which threatens to run dry, they become a river which has many tributaries and no matter how great the outflow, the input just seems to keep pace. **When a person is a reservoir he is controlled by what he has and grieved by what he gives,** because he continually measures his success and effectiveness by what he has accumulated.

When we have the heart of God and truly have become a steward we measure our success by what we have given rather

than by what we have received or kept. Giving truly becomes an investment in His kingdom. Investing in His kingdom produces eternal results.

The reward of the true giver is not the harvest, but the opportunity to sow.

LEARNING TO LIVE THE BLESSED LIFE

ADVENTUROUS GIVING PRODUCES ADVENTEROUS LIVING

TEXT: Luke 6:38 (KJV) *“Give, and it shall be given unto you; good measure, pressed down, and shaken together, and running over, shall men give into your bosom. For with the same measure that ye mete withal it shall be measured to you again.”* Luke 6:38 (NLT) *“If you give, you will receive. Your gift will return to you in full measure, pressed down, shaken together to make room for more, and running over. Whatever measure you use in giving—large or small—it will be used to measure what is given back to you.”*

INTRO: An adventure is an exploration of new territory, the discovery of new horizons, and the discovery of new things. I am a very adventurous person; I enjoy forging ahead in uncharted waters and discovering new and improved ways of doing things. I thrive on a challenge. My dream vacation is to float the Colorado river through the Grand Canyon!

Giving is an adventure that if taken seriously can lead to blessings yet untapped. The reason I decided to title this lesson “*Adventurous Giving*” is because it is my opinion that most of us have never pressed beyond the norm in our giving to discover what is available to those who take the next step.

As a human being we are natural born takers rather than givers. As soon as we are born we learn to make our presence known through crying and develop as an adolescent through selfish antics. The spiritual development of each believer is much like that of the human being. There are **four steps of human and spiritual development**:

- **The baby stage...** A baby thinks only of self, and if denied it will raise a ruckus. It seeks its own way. Its feelings are easily hurt, and it is often jealous. It cries but never sings. It tries to talk but never makes sense.

A baby loves to be served but it never serves. It drinks milk and cannot digest solid foods.

- **The little child stage...** Children are often untruthful, envious, and cruel. If rebuked they become martyrs. If crossed they become resentful and often make a scene. They are talebearers repeating everything they hear (In adults it is known as gossip). They are given to emotional outbursts and are easily offended. They love praise and will accept it from any source. They seek only the things that appeal to self.
- **The young adult stage...** They are strong and agile and well able to overcome most any enemy. They have vision and faith for the future, along with the courage and tenacity to tackle it. They are in preparation for the productive years of their lives.
- **The parent stage...** They have peace with God; rejoice in their children; have learned to be content with the circumstances; know the source of real strength; do not brood over the past but look with faith to the future; know that all things work together for the good; they enjoy life now and look expectantly to eternal life.

While we are natural born takers, the nature of God is to give. John 3:16 (KJV) ***“For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.”*** I cannot refrain from asking this question, *“If the nature of God is to give and we have been born again by His spirit, shouldn’t we begin to love to give as well?”*

One aspect of the adventure of giving is the fact that we cannot out-give God. To begin with, how would we ever purpose to give a greater gift than He gave when He sent His son to this earth to die for our sins?

God will be indebted to no man. Mark 10:29-30 (KJV) ***“And Jesus answered and said, Verily I say unto you, There is no man that hath left house, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or***

mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my sake, and the gospel's, 30 But he shall receive an hundredfold now in this time, houses, and brethren, and sisters, and mothers, and children, and lands, with persecutions; and in the world to come eternal life.”

I. ADVENTUROUS GIVING APPLIES THE PRINCIPLE OF BELIEVING AND RECEIVING...

An adventure requires three things:

- Faith...
- Courage...
- Stick-to-it-ness...

When we look at giving from the perspective of being an adventure we immediately know that we **MUST** experience the blessing of the Lord in order for the adventure to be successful. Very simply put, being blessed means that we have supernatural power working for us.

Being blessed means that our days are filled with Divine coincidences and heavenly meaning. A blessed person may not be a millionaire but their path is filled with purpose, passion, and quality of life which many billionaires would be envious of!

While discussing the Law of the Tithe, in five separate places in the book of Deuteronomy God tells His people that if they will walk in His ways He will bless them. [Deuteronomy 14:29](#) (NLT) *“Give it to the Levites, who have no inheritance among you, as well as to the foreigners living among you, the orphans, and the widows in your towns, so they can eat and be satisfied. Then the LORD your God will bless you in all your work.”* [Deuteronomy 15:10](#) (NLT) *“Give freely without begrudging it, and the LORD your God will bless you in everything you do.”* [Deuteronomy 23:20](#) (NLT) *“You may charge interest to foreigners, but not to Israelites, so the LORD your God may bless you in everything you do in the land you are about to enter and occupy.”* [Deuteronomy 28:8](#) (NLT)

“The LORD will bless everything you do and will fill your storehouses with grain. The LORD your God will bless you in the land he is giving you.” Deuteronomy 28:12 (NLT) “The LORD will send rain at the proper time from his rich treasury in the heavens to bless all the work you do. You will lend to many nations, but you will never need to borrow from them.”

The blessed life is finding the sweet spot in this world where the favor of God is obviously on whatever we set our hand to do and then walking in it. [In what areas of our lives can we expect the blessing of the Lord?](#)

- Spiritual walk...
- Health...
- Relationships...
- Work...
- Emotions...
- Thoughts...

II. ADVENTUROUS GIVING APPLIES THE PRINCIPLE OF DOUBTING AND DOING WITHOUT...

If being blessed means to have supernatural power working for us, then being cursed means having supernatural power working against us. If person has supernatural power working for them, there is no way they can fail! Conversely, a person who has supernatural power working against them cannot succeed, no matter how many resources they have at their disposal!

One way to get a curse on our lives is to refuse to do what the Word of God has to say about giving. [Malachi 3:8-9 \(KJV\)](#)

“Will a man rob God? Yet ye have robbed me. But ye say, Wherein have we robbed thee? In tithes and offerings. 9 Ye are cursed with a curse: for ye have robbed me, even this whole nation.”

Have Vicki Lee come up for an interview:

- If a person steals money from the bank, what happens?
- Would the fact that the person was going through hard times give them immunity?
- Would their relationship with you keep them from being prosecuted?
- Will the bank expect restitution?
- Why would the bank, which has so many resources, pick on a person who is just trying to overcome a bad time in their life?

Would you agree that a person who knowingly and willfully steals from a bank should be prosecuted and pay the penalty? When we knowingly and willfully steal from God's storehouse we willingly place ourselves in a position of calling on supernatural powers to work against us. If supernatural powers are at work against us, we will not succeed.

III. ADVENTUROUS GIVING ALWAYS MAKES GOD THE PRIORITY...

If we are going to live the blessed life, we must put first things first. In so doing, [God must occupy the number one slot in our life.](#)

It is my opinion that the way we handle our money speaks volumes about where our priorities have been placed. [Matthew 6:19-21 \(NLT\)](#) ***“Don’t store up treasures here on earth, where they can be eaten by moths and get rusty, and where thieves break in and steal. 20 Store your treasures in heaven, where they will never become moth-eaten or rusty and where they will be safe from thieves. 21 Wherever your treasure is, there your heart and thoughts will also be.”***

I know there will be people who will say that I should have used some other subject to establish where our priorities have been placed, but did you know that there are, 500 Scriptures in the Bible concerning prayer; 500 verses concerning faith; and more

than 2,000 Scriptures concerning money and possessions?
Jesus talked about money in 16 of His 38 parables! Money is actually a test from God. It is a priority test! Are we passing or failing?

In order to fully understand where our priorities have been placed I want to talk to you about the principle of first-fruits. This precedent was established in the Old Testament book of Exodus. [Exodus 13:2,12,13](#) (NLT) ***“Dedicate to me all the firstborn sons of Israel and every firstborn male animal. They are mine.” 12 All firstborn sons and firstborn male animals must be presented to the LORD. 13 A firstborn male donkey may be redeemed from the LORD by presenting a lamb in its place. But if you decide not to make the exchange, the donkey must be killed by breaking its neck. However, you must redeem every firstborn son.”***

God declared the firstborn belonged to Him 16 times in Scripture! According to Old Testament Law the firstborn was to be sacrificed or redeemed. There was no third choice! When an animal delivered its firstborn it was to be sacrificed and if for some reason it was considered unclean, the person was to take a clean animal from their herd and sacrifice it, thus redeeming the firstborn. Jesus was God's firstborn and He offered him as a sacrifice. He was a real first fruits offering, in that sense He was God's tithe! God gave His tithe in faith before we ever believed. [Romans 5:8](#) (NLT) ***“But God showed his great love for us by sending Christ to die for us while we were still sinners.”*** [Romans 8:29](#) (NLT) ***“For God knew his people in advance, and he chose them to become like his Son, so that his Son would be the firstborn, with many brothers and sisters.”***

The Scripture is clear, God not only requires the firstborn or the first-fruit, but He set the example by giving His firstborn Son, for the sins of His other sons. In the same way, we are to bring the first-fruit and THEN we will see the blessing. The first-fruits allow us to participate in adventurous giving!

Some people want to wait until they can afford to start tithing, but the curse and the devourer will never allow them to be in a

financial position to do so. I recently had a conversation with a person who was not tithing and I told them that it did not matter how much money came into their lives they would never have enough because they would always be carrying their resources in a sack with holes in it! (Illustrate this)

It is interesting to note that God required the firstborn. He did not say to allow the ewe to bear nine lambs and then give number ten to God. He said give the firstborn to Him. The prophet told the widow to bake him a cake first and when she did, the meal in the barrel never failed to be present. [It is possible to be a tither without adhering to the principle of first-fruits.](#)

Why did God go beyond requiring the tithe to requiring the first-fruits? Because [it doesn't take faith to give one out of ten, but it requires great faith to give the first-fruit and believe Him to multiply it ten times!](#) Giving the last tenth allows for no adventure, but giving the first tenth brings the tight rope of adventure into play.

Have you ever wondered how God could justify taking the lives of the first born in Egypt? This is because they already belonged to Him. They had not been released to Him through human authority, but they were His to do whatever He wanted. Remember this: God is going to get what belongs to Him; if I release it to Him I get blessed; if I refuse to release it to Him He will get His another way and I place myself under a curse for not being obedient!

The first born in Israel didn't die that night did they? Why not? Because God redeemed the firstborn with a spotless lamb! [Exodus 12:7,13](#) (NLT) **"They are to take some of the lamb's blood and smear it on the top and sides of the doorframe of the house where the lamb will be eaten. 13 The blood you have smeared on your doorposts will serve as a sign. When I see the blood, I will pass over you. This plague of death will not touch you when I strike the land of Egypt."**

Have you ever wondered why God respected Abel's offering but rejected Cain's? [Genesis 4:3-5](#) (KJV) ***"And in process of time it came to pass, that Cain brought of the fruit of the ground an offering unto the LORD. 4 And Abel, he also brought of the firstlings of his flock and of the fat thereof. And the LORD had respect unto Abel and to his offering: 5 But unto Cain and to his offering he had not respect. And Cain was very wroth, and his countenance fell."*** Abel brought the firstborn; Cain brought his offering in the process of time; when he decided to; when he got around to it!

Why did God require that everything in Jericho be destroyed? Because it was the first city conquered in the Promised Land. It was the first-fruits! Why did Achan get into so much trouble for taking a little gold, silver and clothing from the city? Because he was attempting to rob God of the first-fruits!

Remember this: *"Any first thing given is never lost, any first thing not given is always lost."* (Robert Morris) In other words what we give to God is never lost because He redeems it for us, but what we withhold from him will always be lost. [Matthew 16:25](#) (NLT) ***"If you try to keep your life for yourself, you will lose it. But if you give up your life for me, you will find true life."***

The first-fruit of our lives belong to God:

- Our devotion...
- Our time...
- Our talent...
- Our possessions...
- Our finances...

What are we to do with the first-fruits? [Proverbs 3:9-10](#) (NKJV) ***"Honor the LORD with your possessions, And with the first-fruits of all your increase; 10 So your barns will be filled with***

plenty, And your vats will overflow with new wine.” These verses point out the following principles:

- Tithing is a priority of God... *“Honor the Lord with your possessions...”*
- First-fruits are required... Honor him, *“...With the first fruits of your increase...”*
- We will experience Gods provision... *“Your barns will be filled with plenty...”*
- We can expect Him to bless us in a spiritual sense... *“Your vats will overflow with new wine...”*

Just as the firstborn and first-fruit belong to God, the tithe belongs to Him as well. [Leviticus 27:30](#) (NKJV) *“And all the tithe of the land, whether of the seed of the land or of the fruit of the tree, is the LORD’s. It is holy to the LORD.”*

Some will say this is an Old Testament principle, but in reality, it is a God principle. [Malachi 3:6](#) (NKJV) *“For I am the LORD, I do not change...”* [Romans 11:16](#) (NKJV) *“For if the first-fruit is holy, the lump is also holy; and if the root is holy, so are the branches.”* [Matthew 23:23](#) (NLT) *“How terrible it will be for you teachers of religious law and you Pharisees. Hypocrites! For you are careful to tithe even the tiniest part of your income, but you ignore the important things of the law—justice, mercy, and faith. You should tithe, yes, but you should not leave undone the more important things.”*

Many blessings are promised to those who become tithers but the first-fruit offering is the trigger on the blessing. I hope you will pull the trigger today!

In 1998 the body of Christ around the world earned an estimated \$15.2 Billion dollars. The total amount given to churches and church related causes was \$270 billion. This equates to only 1.8%. I am sure you are thinking the same thing I thought when I heard these figures. This includes all the impoverished nations of the world! During the same period, in

the U.S. Christians earned 5.2 trillion dollars but gave only \$92 billion dollars. This equates to only 1.7 %! This means the impoverished nations of the world are more generous than the affluent American church. It is time for God's people to step up to the plate and tithe, doing so by pulling the trigger of first-fruits!

CONCLUSION:

The following principles should be followed when engaging in the adventure of tithing the first-fruit:

- The tithe of first-fruit is 10% of total family income...
- The tithe of first-fruit belongs in the local church...
- The tithe of first-fruit should never be directed or earmarked...

When we view giving as an adventure we are excited about the exploration of new territory, the discovery of new horizons, and the unearthing of new things. We are constantly looking for new opportunities to give, and when we do so, we have the opportunity to go where we have never gone and do what we have never done! That, my friend, is a true adventure!

LEARNING TO LIVE THE BLESSED LIFE

KEYS TO ABUNDANCE

TEXT: Genesis 14:18-20 (CEV) *“King Melchizedek of Salem was a priest of God Most High. He brought out some bread and wine 19 and said to Abram: “I bless you in the name of God Most High, Creator of heaven and earth. 20 All praise belongs to God Most High for helping you defeat your enemies.” Then Abram gave Melchizedek a tenth of everything.”* Deuteronomy 26:1-2,13-14 (NKJV) *“And it shall be, when you come into the land which the LORD your God is giving you as an inheritance, and you possess it and dwell in it,2 “that you shall take some of the first of all the produce of the ground, which you shall bring from your land that the LORD your God is giving you, and put it in a basket and go to the place where the LORD your God chooses to make His name abide.13 “then you shall say before the LORD your God: ‘I have removed the holy tithe from my house, and also have given them to the Levite, the stranger, the fatherless, and the widow, according to all Your commandments which You have commanded me; I have not transgressed Your commandments, nor have I forgotten them.14 ‘I have not eaten any of it when in mourning, nor have I removed any of it for an unclean use, nor given any of it for the dead. I have obeyed the voice of the LORD my God, and have done according to all that You have commanded me.” Matthew 23:23 (NLT) *“How terrible it will be for you teachers of religious law and you Pharisees. Hypocrites! For you are careful to tithe even the tiniest part of your income, but you ignore the important things of the law—justice, mercy, and faith. You should tithe, yes, but you should not leave undone the more important things.”**

INTRO: Since I am dealing with the subject “**Keys to Abundance**” I want to make sure I am very clear; I in no way want to leave the impression that when we give we are

guaranteed great riches. What I am saying however, is that when we get our attitude right in the giving department, we set ourselves up to be blessed in so many ways that it would deplete the space on my hard drive to tell you how many avenues of blessing the lord could choose while blessing us.

Keys are what is used to unlock a door and grant an individual access to an otherwise inaccessible room. Webster defines a key in this manner: *“An instrument used for moving the bolt of a lock thus locking or unlocking something.”* During the course of this message we are going to discover three keys to abundance:

- The key of giving...
- The key of multiplication...
- The key of breaking the spirit of mammon...

Many well meaning Christians use the excuse that tithing is required under the law but the New Testament does not mandate it. Tithing was initiated 430 years before the law was given. (Abraham – in our text) According to the book of Galatians Abraham is our spiritual father and Melchizedek is a type of Christ. The writer of Hebrews echoes these very words. Hebrews 5:9-10 (NKJV) ***“And having been perfected, He became the author of eternal salvation to all who obey Him,¹⁰ called by God as High Priest “according to the order of Melchizedek.”*** The entire seventh chapter of Hebrews is dedicated to showing how Jesus is the fulfillment of all the types and shadows embodied in Melchizedek. It gives particular attention to the fact that Abraham paid tithe to Melchizedek. Hebrews 7:1-3 (NKJV) ***“For this Melchizedek, king of Salem, priest of the Most High God, who met Abraham returning from the slaughter of the kings and blessed him,² to whom also Abraham gave a tenth part of all, first being translated “king of righteousness,” and then also king of Salem, meaning “king of peace,”³ without father, without mother, without genealogy, having neither beginning***

of days nor end of life, but made like the Son of God, remains a priest continually.”

Melchizedek’s titles were “**King of righteousness**” and “**King of peace**.” Of course, Jesus has become our righteousness and peace.

Before we move on from the subject of Abraham and Melchizedek I want us to look at one more passage. Hebrews 7:8 (NKJV) “**Here mortal men receive tithes, but there he receives them, of whom it is witnessed that he lives.**”

The principle of tithing was also adhered to under the Law of Moses. (Israel entering Canaan – in our text) The principle of tithing runs through the New Testament as well. (Pharisees – in our text) In addition, I want us to look at what Paul had to say concerning this subject. 1 Corinthians 16:1-2 (KJV) “**Now concerning the collection for the saints, as I have given order to the churches of Galatia, even so do ye. 2 Upon the first day of the week let every one of you lay by him in store, as God hath prospered him, that there be no gatherings when I come.**” Even in Paul’s day the responsibility of Christian giving was tied to the amount the person earned. I suggest to you that Paul is saying that each person should give 10% and if everyone would do that there would be no need to receive a love offering for him when he came for a ministry visit because the resources would be readily available.

The Scriptures I have just used proves beyond a doubt that the principle of tithing and giving is not just merely a component of the Law of Moses, but a principle which runs the length and breadth of the Bible. It is not a Law thing it is a Bible thing...

ILLUSTRATION: What if I came in this service this morning, pulled out a revolver and randomly picked one person to kill and used as my excuse, “*Thou shalt not kill was a part of the Law of Moses and I am living under grace, therefore I am not affected by the law?*” Every person here would no doubt point out to me that the principle of the sanctity of human life is

a common thread which predates and surpasses the Law of Moses. That's right, and so does the principle of tithing...

Grace actually requires more than law...

The Law said not to commit murder! (Exodus 20:13, Deuteronomy 5:17) Jesus said, *"Don't even be angry with your brother."* (Matthew 5:22)

The Law said not to commit adultery! (Exodus 20:14, Deuteronomy 5:18) Jesus said, *"If you look at a woman with lust in your heart you have already committed adultery."*

The demands of grace are greater than that of the Law, so if we prefer to give according to grace rather than Law we will go beyond the expectations of the Law...

I. THE KEY OF GIVING...

I would tend to believe that everyone in my audience today would prefer to live in abundance rather than live with lack in our life. This is probably not going to sound very spiritual but I have tried poverty and I have tried a little bit of prosperity and my personal preference is prosperity.

The first key to abundance is giving. I should probably hasten on to say that the key to giving is attitude rather than ability. We cannot talk about giving without talking about stewardship. We are stewards for God; we are his business managers; everything we have belongs to the Lord. When we realize who owns it all it is not nearly as difficult to follow His will in giving. If I give it all away at His direction, it is alright because there is more where that came from.

ILLUSTRATION: One day Larissa had a \$20.00 bill and could not get change and had need of two dollars. I offered to trade her two one dollar bills for her twenty and she readily agreed. I wanted to use this as a teaching opportunity on the value of the dollar and so I explained to her what kind of trade she had just made. She had reduced her net worth by \$18.00 to meet a momentary need. Her response was *"It's OK Dad, there's more where that came from!"*

I am God's steward, what I have belongs to Him, He can direct it as He pleases, and when He asks for it all I must remember *"It's OK Dad, there's more where that came from."* The stewardship principle is as old as humankind. Adam and Eve were stewards (caretakers) of the garden. They were told not to eat of one tree in the garden. Genesis 2:15-17 (NLT) **"The LORD God placed the man in the Garden of Eden to tend and care for it. 16 But the LORD God gave him this warning: "You may freely eat any fruit in the garden 17 except fruit from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. If you eat of its fruit, you will surely die."** Why did God get so ticked when they decided to disobey and eat of the forbidden tree? The answer is, they were acting like owners rather than stewards. This attitude points to a conflict between ownership and stewardship. An attitude of ownership will cause you to be upset when the Pastor preaches on finances. An attitude of stewardship will cause us to set up and pay attention to any teaching which allows us a little more information on how to manage the assets of the Master who has placed us in charge of his things. While we are stewards, He allows us to enjoy the fruit of His increase in this life. 1 Timothy 6:17 (NLT) **"Tell those who are rich in this world not to be proud and not to trust in their money, which will soon be gone. But their trust should be in the living God, who richly gives us all we need for our enjoyment."**

When it comes to giving, God has given us stewardship responsibilities over our lives. While we have stewardship responsibilities, we must not touch anything He has placed as off limits for us. We have established that the tithe belongs to the Lord and the person who touches the tithe is doing exactly what Adam and Eve did in the garden.

The key of giving and tithing is a test for all up and coming stewards. Jesus reveals the acid test of stewardship in Matthew 6:21 (NLT) ***"Wherever your treasure is, there your heart and thoughts will also be."***

Did you know the word translated ***“Tithe”*** in the Bible literally means *“Tenth”* or *“Tenth part?”* Throughout the Bible the number ten represents testing...

- How many plagues came upon Egypt? Ten...
- How many commandments are there? Ten...
- How many times did God test Israel in the wilderness? Ten...
- How many times did God test Jacob’s heart while working for Laban? Ten...
- How many day’s was Daniel tested in Daniel chapter one? Ten...
- The preparedness of the virgins was tested in Matthew 25. How many virgins were there? Ten...
- How many days of testing are mentioned in Revelation 2:10? Ten...

Tithing and giving is the defining test of all would-be-stewards. This is also the only area in which we are admonished to test God. Malachi 3:10 (NKJV) ***“Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this,” Says the LORD of hosts, “If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it.”***

ILLUSTRATION: Suppose I am going to be gone on a trip for several months. I choose three guys to which I commit to send \$10,000.00 per week and my only requirement is that they give Susan \$1,000.00 per man per week. They keep \$9,000.00 and give her \$1,000.00. I suppose I could get any number of participants for that scenario! Suppose after one month I check back with her and discover the first guy has been giving her \$2,000.00 each week, the second guy is giving her \$1,000.00 per week, but the third guy gave her \$800.00 the first week, \$500.00 the next week, and nothing for the final two weeks?

What would you expect me to do? I would fire the third guy and send the first guy \$20,000.00 per week! Right? Sure, it just makes good business sense! The third guy getting mad and throwing a fit because he was fired makes about as much sense as a Christian refusing to tithe and expecting to reap the blessings of the Lord! Let me give you a Scripture for this.

Matthew 25:29 (NLT) **“To those who use well what they are given, even more will be given, and they will have an abundance. But from those who are unfaithful, even what little they have will be taken away.”**

Before we move on from this subject I want to digress to the relationship between Abraham and Melchizedek. The writer of Hebrews reveals an all important truth concerning this relationship as well as the relationship of our tithe and who we are giving them to. Hebrews 7:8 (NKJV) **“Here mortal men receive tithes, but there he receives them, of whom it is witnessed that he lives.”** We may think we are returning our tithe through the auspices of the local church but according to this New Testament Scripture when they are placed on deposit in our local church a far greater entity is keeping up with our giving record. We should return our tithe with the same intensity as we would if we had to stand at the pearly gates and return them to Jesus himself!

- What a privilege...
- What an opportunity...
- What a Holy act of worship...

Tithing is not a grim duty to be performed by the Christian. It is not a dry religious exercise which kills the Spirit of a service. It is not punishment intended to cost the believer hard earned cash. It is a wonderful opportunity to invest in the kingdom of God and in doing so; it brings unbelievable benefits to the tither not to mention protection from the devourer.

The first key to abundance is without question, tithing! If we cannot pass the tithing test with a good attitude we can forget

being in possession of any of the other keys. It is really this simple; if we tithe with a good attitude we are blessed; if we do not tithe with a good attitude we are cursed.

II. KEY OF MULTIPLICATION...

Have we ever wanted or felt that we needed to multiply something?

- Multiply ourselves to get all our work done?
- Multiply the hours in a day?
- Multiply money to pay our bills?

Webster defines multiplication in the following way: *“A method used to find the result of adding a specified quantity repeatedly a specific number of times.”*

The Bible is full of instances of the miracle of multiplication:

- The strength of Israelite soldiers was multiplied on many occasions when they were hopelessly outnumbered...
- The meal and oil of the widow and her son was multiplied...
- The multiplication of a little boy's lunch...

I want us to zero in on this miracle of multiplication here in Luke 9 which outlines how Jesus took a meal of fish and chips from Long John Silvers and fed a multitude of people.

Jesus blessed the little boys lunch and told the disciples to give it away! Can you imagine what Peter or for that part, Thomas must have been thinking as they walked into the crowd with a half a handful of fish and bread and 5,000 men to feed? I would give anything to be able to record the thoughts of the disciples...

- Peter – Walking on water is one thing, but this is ridiculous...

- Thomas – I doubt if this is going to work...
- John – I love Jesus but we've never done it like this before...
- Andrew – How is this going to work, there are more people than there is lunch...
- Luke – My medical education tells me there is not enough here to feed this crowd...
- Judas – All He is going to do is stir up these hungry folks and I will have to bankrupt the treasury to settle them down...
- James – I know He has performed a lot of miracles but I think He has over loaded himself this time...

The thing that Jesus knew that the disciples were not aware of was the key of multiplication! Jesus may have fed upwards of 20,000 people that day with five loaves and two fish and took up twelve baskets of fragments!

There are at least two components to utilizing the key of multiplication. The first key: A thing must be blessed before it can multiply! Jesus blessed the fish and bread before he distributed it to the multitudes.

If we desire to use the key of multiplication in our finances we must first bless them. How do we bless them? Pray over them dedicating the first-fruit to God, then following through to complete our part of the covenant. Romans 11:16 (NKJV) ***“For if the first-fruit is holy, the lump is also holy; and if the root is holy, so are the branches.”*** What this Scripture does not say is almost as important as what it does say. If the first-fruit is misapplied everything that follows after it is also cursed.

There are many sweet well-intentioned Christians who have never personally witnessed the miracle of multiplication where their resources are concerned. It is not that they are bad people;

they have just never understood the principle of blessing the first-fruit by giving it to the Lord.

Remember, we are not giving our tithes to the preacher or the church, but to the Lord. If we dedicate our first-fruit to Him it makes the rest of our finances Holy and then the remainder is available for the miracle of multiplication!

The second component of the key of multiplication is as simple as the first. Only what is given away can multiply! The disciples were handling blessed bread which now had the power of multiplication on it! It had been blessed so it had the potential for multiplication! If the disciples had decided to eat the meal themselves, it would not have been enough for twelve people but when they started to give it away they witnessed the miracle of multiplication. If they used the lunch for themselves they would have had a couple of bites each instead of full stomachs and twelve baskets of leftovers!

Even though the food was blessed it had to be given away in order for it to multiply. I am here to remind us today that only what we give away can be multiplied! If we need a financial blessing we must find a way to sow a financial seed!

Tithing is not giving it is returning what belongs to God to begin with. Tithing begins the process of multiplication but where we get into the miracle of multiplication is what we give away above our tithe! A portion of our finances over-and-above our tithe must be shared if they are to be multiplied. Tithing is where we remove the curse, giving above our tithe is where multiplication begins.

King Hezekiah witnesses the key of multiplication when he required the people to tithe of the first-fruit and the first-born. 2 Chronicles 31:4-10 (NLT) **“In addition, he required the people in Jerusalem to bring the prescribed portion of their income to the priests and Levites, so they could devote themselves fully to the law of the LORD. 5 The people responded immediately and generously with the first of their crops and grain, new wine, olive oil, honey, and all the produce of their fields. They**

brought a tithe of all they owned. 6 The people who had moved to Judah from Israel, and the people of Judah themselves, brought in the tithes of their cattle and sheep and a tithe of the things that had been dedicated to the LORD their God, and they piled them up in great heaps. 7 The first of these tithes was brought in late spring, and the heaps continued to grow until early autumn. 8 When Hezekiah and his officials came and saw these huge piles, they thanked the LORD and his people Israel! 9 “Where did all this come from?” Hezekiah asked the priests and Levites. 10 And Azariah the high priest, from the family of Zadok, replied, “Since the people began bringing their gifts to the LORD’s Temple, we have had enough to eat and plenty to spare, for the LORD has blessed his people.”

The key of multiplication is inserted into the lock of life when the individual Christian tithes. Giving above our tithe is turning the key in the lock of multiplication. It would be well to note that when EVERYONE in a local church exercises the key of multiplication it catapults the people and the church into a place of **“Not enough room to receive it.”** I believe the **“Not enough room to receive it”** principle is enacted first corporately, then individually.

Can you imagine what one congregation the size of this one could do if everyone tithed every week? There would not be one person in this congregation who would be in lack because the resources of the church would be sufficient to meet the needs of the hurting until they could stand on their own two feet and become a part of the multiplication process.

III. KEY OF BREAKING THE SPIRIT OF MAMMON...

Mammon is not really a word we go around using everyday but Jesus used this word in Matthew 6:24 (NKJV) ***“No one can serve two masters; for either he will hate the one and love the other, or else he will be loyal to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and mammon.”*** The fact that Jesus so clearly states that it is just as possible to serve mammon as it is

to serve God, and even states that no one can serve both mammon and God at the same time, suggests to me that He is clearly defining mammon as an idol which people worship, serve and bow down to.

Mammon is an Aramaic word that essentially means riches. Jesus draws a striking contrast between the spirit of mammon and the spirit of God. He is saying that they are so diametrically opposed that it is not possible to serve both at once. Look at what Jesus say's:

- No one can serve two masters...
- He will hate one and love the other...
- He will be loyal to one and despise the other...

There is no middle of the road here; no half-in-half; no neutrality; no fence straddling will be permitted on this subject. The spirit of mammon is founded on pride and arrogance. The attitude of the spirit of mammon is:

- Man does not need God...
- Man is a little god himself...
- Man is self-sufficient...
- Man should trust in his own riches...

In the spiritual sense mammon is a spirit which trusts in riches. If I am being seduced by the spirit of mammon my security is judged by the size of my bank account. All money has a spirit attached to it. It either has the spirit of God working in it or the spirit of mammon working through it. Money which has been submitted to God and His purposes has the spirit of God on it. This is why it multiplies and cannot be affected by the devourer. Money which is devoted to God and His purposes rather than making an attempt to replace Him is blessed by God.

Money which has not been submitted to God has the spirit of mammon on it by default. To not pay our tithes is an automatic invitation for the spirit of mammon to rule over our finances and our lives. The spirit of mammon:

- Makes an attempt to buy happiness... Things cannot satisfy...
- Makes an attempt to control others with the almighty dollar... Always paying the check then causing others to feel as if they are in debt...
- Makes an attempt to manipulate others by proving I am more prosperous than you... Because of my things I should be listened to...
- Makes a person believe they are a self-made man... Everything we have comes from, and belongs to God...

The spirit of mammon is looking for servants! It is seeking worshippers! It will promise you everything but deliver emptiness! The spirit of mammon is alive and well both inside and outside the church.

The spirit of mammon uses the oldest trick in the world, a trick which was used on Adam and Eve and even on Jesus in the wilderness, it promises to deliver on the things that only God can deliver on:

- Security...
- Significance...
- Identity...
- Independence...
- Power...
- Freedom...

When you think about it, mammon is nothing more than the system of this fallen world that stands in sharp opposition to God and his ways:

- Mammon say's to buy and sell; God say's to sow and reap...
- Mammon say's to take; God say's to give...
- Mammon say's to cheat and steal; God say's to give and receive...
- Mammon is selfish; God is generous...
- Mammon say's to hoard everything you can; God say's to give it away cheerfully...

I want you to hear what I am about to say; money and mammon are not synonymous; money is not inherently evil. 1 Timothy 6:10 (NKJV) ***“For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil, for which some have strayed from the faith in their greediness, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows.”*** You can love money without having it and you can have it without loving it. I know more people who love it and do not have it than I do which have it and are in love with it. It is the love of money which perverts the owner.

Greed, covetousness and selfishness are all manifestations of the spirit of mammon. Because mammon is a spirit, it is constantly talking to us. Mammon sounds like this:

- If you have the right car you will be accepted...
- If you live in the right house you will be respected...
- If you get the next promotion you will be esteemed more highly...
- If you have the right credit cards you can get what it takes to get a leg up in life...

- If you can get acquainted with the right people you can get where you have always wanted to be...

The bottom line is that the spirit of mammon will tell you that *"if you can somehow beg, borrow, steal or manipulate your way to the top you will be happy."* The spirit of mammon will tell you that *"if God does not provide a miracle right away, you are going to need a lot of money to overcome this setback."* This is a lie, what we need is God and nothing else! If we have God, He will take care of everything else we need because He alone is our source!

The spirit of mammon has two constant companions:

- The spirit of poverty – This spirit keeps a person in poverty by making them believe they cannot be spiritual and blessed at the same time! This spirit will cause a believer say things like *"Wealth is not spiritual"* or when they get blessed they will say, *"I don't want this blessing because I don't deserve this blessing."* When a person operating in a spirit of poverty gets blessed with a better house and someone notices their blessing, rather than saying *"This is such a blessing from the Lord"* they will say things like, *"Yes, it was repossession and we were able to acquire it far below market value, otherwise we could not have afforded it."* Poverty say's, *"I bought this outfit at Wal-Mart."* It is time for God's children to quit apologizing for their blessings, recognize where the blessings are coming from, and give God the full credit He deserves for what is going right in our lives.
- The spirit of pride – The spirit of pride causes a person to keep running into debt attempting to keep up their public image, while living beyond their means! When our outgo exceeds our income, our upkeep becomes our downfall! The spirit of pride also say's, *"Wealth comes from hard work."* The spirit of pride causes a person to flaunt their wealth. A spirit of pride say's *"This outfit*

was imported from Europe.” This is no time for God’s children to be running to debt to keep up their public image. It is time to do what is right with our finances and then sit back and await the blessings of the Lord. When we receive a blessing, we should give God the glory rather than attempting to flaunt our new found success.

Matthew 6:24 (NKJV) *“No one can serve two masters; for either he will hate the one and love the other, or else he will be loyal to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and mammon.”* 1 Timothy 6:10 (NKJV) *“For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil, for which some have strayed from the faith in their greediness, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows.”* We are not being told here to hate money, we are being told to hate the spirit of mammon! The spirit of mammon is always accompanied by a greedy, selfish, lying, deceiving, Antichrist like spirit which flourishes in the atmosphere of money worship. I am not one to fight other ministries but I see this same spirit raising its ugly head in many national and international ministries. It is all about money. I am not presenting this as a get-rich-quick-scheme, I am presenting it as a lay-down-our-life and take-up-His practice!

The bottom line is we cannot worship God and mammon; we will hate one and love the other! When we begin to worship mammon we will step farther and farther from the will of God.

Matthew 6:19-21 (NKJV) *“Do not lay up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy and where thieves break in and steal;20 “but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust destroys and where thieves do not break in and steal.21 “For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.”* When we use money for unrighteous or greedy purposes we are placing it at great risk of destruction. When we use money for righteous purposes we are placing it in the safest investment in the universe and it

will gain interest and dividends which can only be measured in eternity! This is a wonderful investment opportunity!

The reason the enemy fights us so hard in the area of our finances is because he knows that dollars can be turned into souls if it is rightly handled. Hell is plundered by our offerings, and Satan knows it! One other reason Satan hates Spirit led giving is because it simultaneously diminishes his kingdom and makes us more like our heavenly Father.

Church leaders have a responsibility to be people of integrity in the area of finances and they will give an account to God for what they did with the offerings! How would you like to be a church leader who stands before God and gives a report that hundreds of thousands of dollars were left in the bank at the rapture? How would you like to be a church leader who stands before God and must give an account for negligent spending practices?

Before I leave the subject of mammon I want to point out one more scripture. Luke 16:11-12 (NLT) ***“And if you are untrustworthy about worldly wealth, who will trust you with the true riches of heaven? 12 And if you are not faithful with other people’s money, why should you be trusted with money of your own?”*** Some people would look at our subject today and say, this does not affect me; I don’t have enough money to worry about it. It does not matter how much money you have, what matters is whose it is! If all we have belongs to God, then it is His money, not ours! If all that I have belongs to God then each new day brings a brand new test of stewardship! Will my resources have the spirit of God resting on them or will they be directed by the spirit of mammon?

The Bible is saying that we must prove ourselves faithful with a little before we will be given more! If you have a little to nothing you are a perfect candidate for the blessing of God because if you will prove to Him you can be faithful with a little He will entrust more to you! A person who is unjust with a little will be unjust with a whole lot more! Christians who cheat with a little will not become faithful when they are rich!

CONCLUSION: Is God speaking to us about money or is the spirit of mammon calling the shots? One or the other is happening! If we say neither is happening then the spirit of mammon has already rocked us to sleep and is in control of our finances by default!

The golden rule for our finances is “*We are Gods stewards and we are managing his resources for Him.*” God reminded Israel of this before they went into Canaan and embarked upon one of the most extraordinary times of national wealth in their history. Deuteronomy 8:18 (NLT) “*Always remember that it is the LORD your God who gives you power to become rich, and he does it to fulfill the covenant he made with your ancestors.*”